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STATE DEMOCRATS NOW FAR COOLER TO ISRAEL

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This just seems startling to me: California Democrats think overwhelmingly that America should not take sides in the horrific war inGaza. But Republicans side strongly with Israel. That's based on a statewide poll conducted by the nonpartisan Public Policy Institute of California. It's startling because formost of mylife, the Democratic Party has emphatically backed Israel and has been solidly supported by Jewish voters and donors. Democrats and Israel have been closely tied. "Democratic candidates get support fromJews because of social issues and their advocacy on behalf of people of color and those struggling financially. That's the Jewish culture," says Democratic strategist Darry Sragow, who is Jewish. Bob Shrum, a former Democratic strategist who nowis director of the Center for the Political Future at USC, points out that "the Democratic leadership still firmly supports Israel. Somepeople are outliers, but they don't represent the majority of elected officials." Yes, but there clearly is a titanic shift in voter support for Israel that has been occurring for years and burst to the surface during the Israeli-Hamas bloodshed. More specifically, there is a generational divide. Younger people are far less supportive of Israel than their elders. APPIC survey in mid-November asked these three questions of California adults, and I'm using the exact wording for context: Have you heard about the "escalating violence in Israel and Palestine?" Practically everyone had-91 percent. Does theUnited States have "a responsibility to do something about the fighting in Israel and the Palestinian territory between Israeli forces and Hamas?" People were split: yes 37 percent, no 36 percent, not sure 27 percent. Then the key question: "In the Israeli-Palestinian conflict, do you think theUnited States should take Israel's side, the Palestinians' side or not take either side?" Among all adults surveyed in California, 61 percent said we should not take either side. Only 28 percent felt that the U.S. should side with Israel, even though America has been that nation's sturdiest ally since its creation in 1948. Nine percent thought the U.S. should support the Palestinians. Abig eye opener was the responses ofDemocrats and Republicans.

Among Democrats, 63 percent said the U.S. should stay neutral. Just 19 percent backed Israel.And almost as many, 16 percent, sided with the Palestinians.By contrast, 59 percent of Republicans said America should back Israel.Ameager 4 percent sided with Palestinians and 37 percent opted for neutrality. "I find these numbers jaw-dropping," says Sacramento-based Republican consultantRob Stutzman. Hethought there'd be more Republicans advocating neutrality, more "non-interventionists." But he notes that Republican evangelical Christians long have supported Israeli control of the Holy Land. Hamas-theGaza-based militant group that started the current war with a murderous, maiming and hostage-taking rampage into Israel on Oct. 7-was notmentioned in the questions. It was all about Israelis vs. Palestinians. People under age 55 were especially for American neutrality. "As the war has gone on, a lot of people would like to see it end- whether that's wishful thinking or not," PPIC polling directorMark Baldassare told me. "Sometimes there's a hope that by not taking sides, they'll find a way to settle the conflict." Iparticularly wanted to hear from Jewish legislatorswhy they thought Democratic voter support for Israel is slipping. "There is an understandable reluctance of folks to get involved in longtermconflicts," says Assemblyman Jesse Gabriel, D-Encino, co-chair of the California Legislative Jewish Caucus. "We're trying to solve problems in other parts of the worldwhile we've got a full plate in the U.S." But there's a lotmore going on than a trend toward less interventionism. As Times reportersDavid Lauter and Jaweed Kaleemwrote last week, "antisemitismhas sprung back to virulence in the U.S. The upsurge began before the war inGaza and has nowaccelerated."

"Antisemitism is often referred to as the oldest hatred," says state Sen. Scott Wiener, D-San Francisco, the other co-chair of the Legislative Jewish Caucus. "It has beenwith us forever and has gottenmore overt." Obviously not everyonewho doesn't support Israel is an antisemite. There are lots of nuances. Start with the worldwide blowback against Israeli PrimeMinister Benjamin Netanyahu's conduct of the war-the relentless bombing and ground attacks that have killed more than 18, 000 Palestinians, two-thirds of themwomenand children. Jewish lawmakers agreed that is one reason Israel is losingDemocratic voter support. State Sen. Steve Glazer, D-Orinda, is a former Democratic political consultant and is Jewish.Hesays there's aproblem in howthe Middle East turmoil has been

"framed" in discussion. "There's language on the surface that appeals toDemocrats-certainly younger people-but does not agree with historical fact," he says. "Simplistic, loaded words like 'colonizers' and 'apartheid.' 'Cease-fire' is another alluring phrase.That's easy to embrace, but is so wrong because it would allowHamasto survive only to repeat this again.Apolitical fight is always about framing." And things that are relatable- such as theHolocaust. Older folks relatemuchmore than young people do to the Holocaust that occurred roughly 80 years ago when the Nazis murdered 6 million Jews. "A lot of us grew up with family and friendswho were survivors," Gabriel recalls. "People sat around the dinner table with [concentration camp]tattoos on their arms." Hesays "the polling that really bothered me" was conducted recently by YouGov for the Economist. It found that one-fifth of Americans ages 18-29 believe the Holocaust was a myth. Another 30 percent said they didn't knowwhether it was a myth. In all, half of American adults under 30 aren't surewhether the Holocaust was fact or fiction. That's clearly a failure of American education.

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